

Public alignment orientation under US–China competition: Hierarchy, identity, and the Japanese case

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Abstract

Alignment orientation has become a defining challenge for middle-power states. The strategic competition between the USA and China places Japan in a central dilemma: securing national defense through the US alliance while sustaining economic prosperity through interdependence with China. We argue that the mass public's alignment orientation under power transition is driven by conditional recognition of regional hierarchy filtered through dominance-oriented dispositions. Using an online survey from January 2024, we show that Social

Dominance Orientation conditions how individuals interpret perceived Chinese influence and shapes their relative preferences over improving relations with China versus the USA, particularly when regional hierarchy appears unsettled rather than consolidated. Cultural similarity with China is the significant predictor of support for economic engagement, highlighting the domain-specific role of identity. Our robustness checks show that the core results remain stable across alternative specifications. The study reframes US–China dynamics as a contest over regional hierarchy and demonstrates how hierarchy preferences shape alignment adjustment under contested power.

Keywords: Japan; China; alignment; social dominance orientation; alliance

1. Introduction

The Asia-Pacific is undergoing a period of pronounced strategic uncertainty. China's rapid military modernization, expanding economic statecraft, and increasingly assertive regional behavior have raised fundamental questions about the future of regional order (Beeson and Murray 2020; Hughes 2022). At the same time, doubts about the durability of US regional leadership—exacerbated by episodes such as the withdrawals from Syria and Afghanistan—have unsettled long-standing assumptions about alliance reliability in Asia (Chan 2022; Zacharias 2025). Under these conditions, secondary states across the region face renewed pressure to reassess how they position themselves between competing great powers.

Japan represents a critical case of this broader regional dilemma. On the security front, advances in China's missile forces, naval capabilities, and power-projection platforms have heightened concerns about Japan's strategic vulnerability in its immediate periphery (Hughes 2022). Economically, China's deep integration into regional production networks—from electronics and automotive components to critical minerals—has increased Japan's exposure to Chinese market leverage (Kawai 2025). At the same time, China's gray-zone activities around the Senkaku/Diaoyu Islands have intensified frictions short of armed conflict (Narushige 2023). These pressures coincide with growing public ambivalence about the reliability of US leadership, even as the US–Japan alliance remains central to Japan's security strategy (Silver, Huang, and Clancy 2023).

This combination of Chinese coercive capacity and uncertainty surrounding US commitment places Japan in a position emblematic of many Asia-Pacific middle powers. Alignment choices are no longer reducible to binary decisions of balancing or bandwagoning. Instead, states—and their publics—must navigate a more fluid environment characterized by overlapping security and economic dependencies (Liff and Ikenberry 2014). We conceptualize alignment in this study as a general foreign-policy orientation toward prioritizing one great power over another across security and economic domains, rather than as adherence to specific policy instruments.

While a large literature has examined Japan's strategic responses through the lenses of hedging, balancing, and alliance politics (Hughes 2016; Liff 2019; Green 2003, 2022), these accounts focus predominantly on elite decision-making and structural constraints. Much less attention has been paid to the domestic foundations of alignment—particularly how ordinary citizens interpret power shifts and evaluate competing great powers. This omission is consequential. Public opinion has long shaped Japanese foreign policy, from constraints imposed by the postwar Peace Constitution to enduring ambivalence over defense normalization (Langdon 1973; Pyle 2007; Kingston 2011). Even as external pressures push Japan toward greater strategic activism, public attitudes continue to condition the scope and pace of policy change (Bobrow 1989; Katzenstein and Okawara 1993; Midford 2011).

This article brings public opinion and political psychology into debates on the Asia-Pacific order by examining how Japanese citizens evaluate alignment under conditions of power transition. We argue that alignment inclination is shaped by the interaction between perceptions of relative power and individual orientations toward hierarchy, captured through Social Dominance Orientation (SDO). SDO reflects a disposition for structured inequality and ordered relations among groups (Pratto et al. 1994; Sidanius and Pratto 1999). People holding SDO tend to endorse dominance-subordination structures (Takahashi, Imada, and Mifune 2025). This disposition has been shown to extend beyond domestic group relations to international politics, where states are likewise interpreted as status-bearing collectives embedded in layered hierarchies (Rathbun et al. 2016; Kertzer 2023). It is also found that SDO predicts the degree to which people react to a change in status in international relations (Masumura and Tago 2023).

Crucially, we contend that SDO matters most when regional hierarchy is ambiguous or contested. When one great power is clearly dominant, alignment posture tends to converge. By contrast, when power relations are in flux—as in the contemporary Asia-Pacific—individuals must interpret uncertain signals about which actor is likely to shape the future order. Hierarchy-oriented individuals are especially attentive to such signals and may become more open to accommodating a rising power, while those less oriented toward hierarchy rely more heavily on identity-based or normative considerations.

Using an original representative nationally online survey conducted in Japan in January 2024, we show that SDO significantly predicts openness to security alignment with China when China's regional influence is perceived as rising but not yet consolidated. In contrast, economic alignment is driven primarily by perceptions of Chinese influence and cultural similarity. These results demonstrate that public responses to power transition in the Asia-Pacific are neither uniform nor purely material, but mediated by psychological orientations toward hierarchy. Our theoretical contribution goes beyond alignment orientation toward a specific state, but reveals the psychological foundations of accommodation, hedging, and resistance during power transitions.

2. Japan as a least-likely case under power transition

Japan provides a theoretically informative case for examining public alignment orientation under contested hierarchy. Structurally, it faces sustained dual pressure: reliance on the USA for extended deterrence alongside deep economic interdependence with China. This configuration exposes Japan to simultaneous security and economic vulnerabilities as regional power relations shift.

Japan is also a least-likely case for accommodation with China. Strong alliance commitments, enduring historical grievances, and widespread public distrust of China raise the political costs of moving away from the USA. Consequently, any observed openness to accommodating China cannot be attributed to pro-China sentiment or economic dependence alone.

Studying Japan therefore offers inferential leverage. Because the case is structurally and normatively biased toward pro-US alignment,

evidence that hierarchy-oriented dispositions shape alignment orientation here suggests the mechanism may be even more consequential in countries such as South Korea, Thailand, or the Philippines, where alignment norms are less settled and security–economic tradeoffs are more fluid.

Finally, public opinion plays a meaningful role in Japanese foreign policy. Democratic accountability, constitutional constraints, and recurrent debates over defense normalization ensure that elite strategies remain sensitive to mass attitudes. Japan thus provides a valuable setting for analyzing how the publics interpret power transition and translate those perceptions into alignment orientation.

3. Theorizing Japanese public opinion on alignment under China's rise

3.1 *Public opinion and alignment choices*

Classic theories of alignment emphasize structural determinants such as relative power, threats, and alliance commitments. Yet foreign policy choices also reflect domestic foundations: how citizens interpret international change and translate it into preferences (Holsti 1992; Tomz, Weeks, and Yarhi-Milo 2020). Individuals draw on assessments of strategic risk, material interests, and identity when evaluating alignment options, but these evaluations are not uniform. They are screened through psychological predispositions that shape how people perceive hierarchy, threat, and intergroup relations (Kertzer and McGraw, 2012; Rathbun et al. 2016). Dispositional traits and cognitive styles influence how both elites and mass publics interpret international hierarchy (Renshon 2017), providing a foundation for linking social psychological orientations to alignment preferences.

In contemporary Japan, this micro-level perspective is increasingly important. Security concerns pull many Japanese citizens toward the USA, while economic interdependence makes China an indispensable partner. Existing work shows that citizens respond to such changes when they perceive shifts in relative power or economic dependence (Baron, Gibbons, and Herzog 2020; Ashley 2023). Yet individuals differ systematically in how they interpret China's rise. These differences

reflect deeper motivational orientations, not merely divergent readings of material conditions. Understanding these predispositions is essential for explaining why some Japanese citizens accommodate China's growing influence, while others prefer continuity with the US-centered order. To build this argument, we focus on three individual-level mechanisms: SDO, perceived relative power, and perceived cultural similarity. Together, these provide a psychological-structural account of how Japanese citizens navigate competing pressures across security and economic domains.

3.2 SDO and hierarchy in international politics

Social dominance theory (SDT) posits that social hierarchies are a fundamental feature of all social systems, typically structured with a small number of dominant groups at the top and subordinate groups at the bottom. Forms of group conflict—such as racism, nationalism, and sexism—reflect individual predispositions toward maintaining such hierarchical arrangements (Sidanius and Pratto 1999). SDO, in turn, is produced and reinforced through intergroup processes and functions as a relatively stable dispositional tendency. It captures individuals' preference for hierarchical, rather than egalitarian, relations among social groups. Because SDO predicts prejudice toward disadvantaged groups, it also reflects a broader preference for hierarchy maintenance (Fischer, Hanke, and Sibley 2012: 439). In our framework, SDO conditions how individuals interpret shifts in power rather than being shaped by those shifts themselves.

Although SDO originates in the study of intergroup relations, it has increasing relevance for foreign policy attitudes, as states can be understood as status-bearing groups embedded within layered international hierarchies. Individuals project their hierarchy preferences onto world politics, using them to interpret international status ordering and power relations. High-SDO individuals are particularly sensitive to hierarchical structure and rank differentiation. Moreover, similar to conservative orientations, SDO is associated with discomfort toward uncertainty (Wilson, Ausman, and Mathews 1973). Contested or ambiguous hierarchies are psychologically aversive for high-SDO individuals because they imply either equality or disorder. Under such conditions, the stability of hierarchy becomes more crucial than the

identity of the hegemon. In this sense, SDO shapes how individuals respond to shifting power relations in international politics. This logic parallels Ikenberry and Kupchan's (1990) argument that elites and publics in secondary states often adjust their policy preferences in response to changing power structures, even without endorsing the dominant actor's legitimacy or values.

This framework is particularly relevant in the case of Japan. While our survey does not directly measure this perception, we argue that such judgments are plausibly shaped by observable signals, including China's expanding military and economic capabilities as well as signs of uncertainty in US leadership, such as domestic polarization, inconsistent international engagement, or doubts about alliance commitments. Under these conditions, individuals higher in SDO evaluate which actor appears most capable of restoring a clear and stable structure. This evaluation is not inherently biased toward either the incumbent or the challenger; rather, it depends on perceived decisiveness, coherence, and capacity to organize the regional environment. When the incumbent order appears weakened or unable to enforce clear status boundaries, continued support for it may no longer satisfy preferences for a stable hierarchy. In such contexts, openness to an alternative source of order is consistent with hierarchy-maintaining motivations. High-SDO individuals may therefore interpret China's rise as evidence of its increasing capacity to structure the region. By contrast, low-SDO individuals are more likely to resist hierarchical realignment, drawing instead on normative commitments or alliance identities. Importantly, SDO reflects a general preference for hierarchy, not unconditional support for either Chinese or US dominance.

Figure 1 illustrates the cognitive pathway of individuals as they move from perceiving a stable order to recognizing a contested one. Hierarchical ambiguity generates psychological discomfort, which motivates a search for resolution. High-SDO individuals then orient toward the actor perceived as most capable of restoring order, potentially leading to a shift in alignment preferences. This distinction between capacity-oriented and loyalty-oriented responses generates the conditional pattern predicted in H3: SDO-driven openness to China emerges only when hierarchy is contested, and attenuates once China is seen as clearly settled at the top of the regional order.

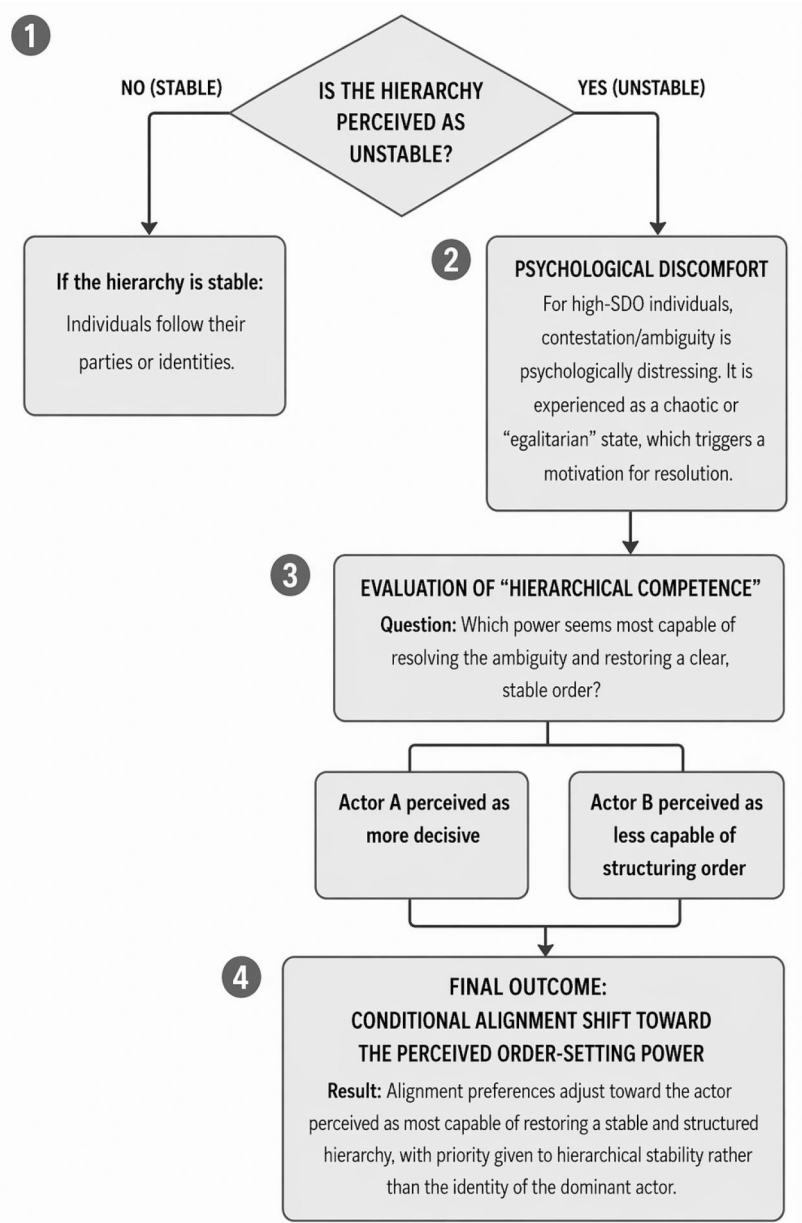


Figure 1 Flowchart of SDO, hierarchy, and alignment preference.

3.3 Perceived power effects

Perceptions of relative power are central to alignment orientation. This insight is well established in classic alliance scholarship (Waltz 1979; Walt 1987; Schweller 1994), and analyses of East Asia (Kang 2009; Liff and Ikenberry 2014). Aligning with China—or at least avoiding direct opposition—may be interpreted as a pragmatic response to a shifting regional order, aimed at maximizing Japan's security and economic interests. Therefore, the perception of Chinese military and economic influence should be positively related to alignment with China. We operationalize perceived dominance using respondents' assessments of China's relative influence in Asia. While dominance and influence are conceptually distinct, in public opinion research, influence perceptions serve as the most direct observable proxy for perceived hierarchical position.

3.4 SDO and conditional hierarchy effects

By integrating psychological dispositions toward hierarchy with perceptions of changing power dynamics, we gain inferential leverage over both the psychological and structural conditions that shape public attitudes toward great-power alignment. When dominance is contested or ambiguous, high-SDO individuals may view accommodation toward an emerging power as a means of stabilizing an evolving hierarchy. However, when power asymmetries become overwhelming or coercive, hierarchy-oriented individuals may resist rather than accommodate, reflecting concerns about disorder, instability, or illegitimate dominance. Hierarchy-oriented individuals may favor American dominance, but they may embrace China when they see China as the emerging authority in East Asia. SDO reflects commitment not to a specific hegemon, but to the maintenance of hierarchical order. Thus, SDO's effect depends on whether individuals believe the USA or China is the dominant actor shaping regional order.¹

1 We acknowledge that alignment orientation may also shape how respondents interpret power trends—particularly among individuals predisposed to favor China. Nevertheless, our analysis supports the moderating pattern, in which SDO predicts pro-China alignment only under conditions of contested hierarchy. This result suggests that alignment orientation is driven by perception rather than attitudinal projection. Future panel or experimental work would help disentangle how perceptions of dominance and alignment disposition co-evolve.

3.5 Cultural similarity and domain-specific orientation

While SDO structures' attitude in the security realm—where hierarchy and coercive power are most salient—attitudes toward economic engagement draw more heavily on identity-based perceptions. Research in international political economy shows that perceptions of cultural proximity and trust shape support for trade, investment, and economic integration (Mansfield and Mutz 2009; Powers, Reifler, and Scotto 2021). In Japan, perceptions of cultural similarity with China can facilitate acceptance of economic interdependence even amid security tensions. Cultural similarity therefore constitutes a distinct, domain-specific mechanism—one that complements but does not depend on hierarchy disposition.

3.6 Partisan identity and foreign policy orientation

Finally, partisan identity provides citizens with ideological cues that shape foreign policy stances (Aldrich et al. 2006; Rathbun 2020). Japanese political parties differ in their approaches to China, the US alliance, and regional security, and these orientations guide followers' alignment choices.

4. Hypotheses

We formulate the following five testable hypotheses based on our theoretical framework. H1 posits that SDO as a disposition can predict alignment preference.

H1 (Hierarchy preference hypothesis): Individuals higher in SDO will be more inclined to adjust their alignment orientation toward the state shaping the regional order.

This hypothesis links psychological orientation directly to individuals' interpretation of East Asia's shifting hierarchy. Because the dependent variable is coded in the pro-China direction, H1 translates empirically into the expectation that SDO will be positively associated with support for China when China is perceived as the dominant or ascendant power.

Based on previous literature on East Asian geopolitics, H2 posits that the perception of Chinese military and economic influence should be positively related to alignment with China.

H2 (Perceived power hypothesis): Higher perceived Chinese military and economic influence increases Japanese citizens' support for accommodating China's rise.

While increases in perceived Chinese influence should generally raise support for accommodating China's rise, this effect is expected to be stronger among individuals low in SDO, who do not anchor their attitude in hierarchical order. For high-SDO individuals, by contrast, the effect of perceived Chinese influence weakens once China is seen as the dominant power, because the alignment decision becomes "overdetermined" by China's hierarchical position. This logic generates the conditional hierarchy hypothesis that SDO increases receptivity to rising powers only when relative power remains uncertain.

H3 (Conditional Hierarchy Hypothesis): The positive effect of perceived Chinese influence on alignment orientation will weaken as SDO increases (SDO $\times$ Power Perception interaction).

H3 posits that high-SDO individuals are more likely to accommodate China as a rising actor when China's power advantage is ambiguous. However, when China's dominance becomes salient, high-SDO individuals may instead favor preserving stability by reinforcing existing hierarchies (i.e., the USA). This produces a conditional—and potentially negative—interaction between SDO and perceived Chinese influence. Together, H2 and H3 capture both the direct impact of China's rising influence and the conditional psychological mechanism shape how individuals interpret it. SDO and perceived power operate as distinct yet complementary pathways shaping alignment orientation.

In addition to perceived hierarchy and power difference, cultural similarity also plays a role in alignment choice, particularly in the economic domain. We propose the following hypothesis:

H4 (Cultural similarity hypothesis): Greater perceived cultural similarity with China increases support for economic engagement with China.

As a long-standing predisposition, party identification may structure people's foreign-policy attitudes. Given that LDP and its allies are

supportive of closer ties with the US, we expect that partisan identification will shape alignment preference as H5 posits.

H5 (Partisanship hypothesis): Partisan identification will shape alignment preference in ways consistent with established foreign policy orientations.

5. Data and method

The study is based on an observational online survey and does not employ experimental randomization. We collaborated with CrossMarketing, one of the largest survey companies in Japan with over 10.51 million panel members, to conduct our online surveys. A total of 1,400 Japanese individuals recruited by CrossMarketing completed the survey online in January 2024; CrossMarketing employed quota sampling based on gender, age, and residential area. The demographic distribution of our samples can be found in the [Supplementary appendix](#).

5.1 Dependent variables

To examine how Japanese citizens perceive the rivalry between the two superpowers, we construct two dependent variables that capture public orientation over strategic alignment. The first focuses on national security: respondents were asked, “Regarding Japan’s national security, do you think Japan should have a better relationship with the United States or China?” The second addresses economic policy and poses a parallel question: “Regarding Japan’s economic interests, do you think Japan should have a better relationship with the United States or China?” In each case, responses are recorded on a 5-point scale: “the relationship with the U.S. is very important,” “the relationship with the U.S. is important,” “both China and the U.S. are important,” “the relationship with China is important,” and “the relationship with China is very important.” The higher value means stronger orientation for alignment with China.

These questions are designed to capture mass attitudes toward foreign policy alignment by asking respondents to consider whether Japan should prioritize strengthening its ties with the USA or cultivating a

closer relationship with China. They do not measure endorsement of China as a hegemon, but reflect willingness to adjust policy orientation toward China rather than the US under perceived power shifts, which is the behavioral outcome that SDO seeks to explain. Rather than conceptualizing alignment as a binary choice, the 5-point scale allows for variation in both direction and intensity, enabling us to differentiate between strong preferences for one power, ambivalent or hedging positions, and openness to accommodation without fully rejecting the US–Japan alliance. Respondents may interpret “better relationship” relative to current baselines, but this feature is theoretically appropriate for capturing directional adjustment rather than absolute regime support.

This measurement strategy reflects the trade-offs Japan faces as it navigates intensifying US–China competition. Drawing on realist insights that secondary states do not always balance against rising powers—and may instead accommodate them to mitigate risk or maximize benefits (Schweller 1994)—the survey situates foreign policy attitudes within a concrete strategic dilemma. By presenting alignment as a choice between building a better relationship with China or the USA, the instrument captures the structural ambiguity and strategic ambivalence that characterize contemporary Japanese foreign policy debates.

Importantly, we disaggregate orientation across security and economic domains, allowing for domain-specific variation in alignment logic. Prior research suggests that individuals often differentiate between these spheres when forming foreign policy attitudes (Christensen 1996; Mearsheimer 2018). The midpoint of the scale—valuing both powers equally—also offers analytical leverage, serving as a proxy for hedging behavior. In doing so, the measure provides a more realistic account of how publics in allied states weigh the competing imperatives of reassurance and openness to relational adjustment toward China.

5.2 Independent variables

Our theoretical framework identifies four core factors shaping alignment orientation: SDO, perceptions of China’s relative influence, cultural similarity, and party identification.

SDO is measured using four items adapted from SDT (Pratto et al. 1994). Respondents indicate their level of agreement with statements capturing support for hierarchy and group-based inequality. The first three items are reverse-coded—"In an ideal world, all nations would be equal," "It is important to treat every nation equally," and "No one group should dominate society"—so that higher values consistently indicate stronger support for intergroup hierarchy. The fourth item is phrased in a pro-hierarchical direction ("Some groups are essentially not equal to others"). After recoding, we conduct a principal factor analysis to extract a unidimensional scale. The resulting index exhibits high internal consistency (Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.83$), a dominant factor (eigenvalue = 2.35), and explains 58% of the total variance. Scores are rescaled to range from 0 to 1.

To measure perceptions of China's geopolitical influence, we ask: "Which of the U.S. or China do you think has more influence in Asia today?" Responses span a 5-point scale from "the U.S. has a lot more influence" to "China has a lot more influence." Higher values indicate stronger perceived Chinese influence over the USA. Because we ask respondents to rank two great powers within the same regional arena, this variable captures how respondents perceive the regional balance of power, a central construct in realist theories of international politics (Gilpin 1981; Mearsheimer 2001). It also enables us to examine whether individuals' strategic orientation is shaped by perceptions of hierarchy beyond materials or identity.

Because our theoretical expectations posit an interaction between SDO and power perceptions, we include an interaction term in our models. If SDO increases relative support for improving relations with China over the USA, but this effect weakens as China is seen as more powerful, it would suggest that psychological predispositions are moderated by structural assessments of the regional order.

To capture the influence of identity, we measure perceived cultural similarity with China by asking respondents, "Do you think Japanese and Chinese cultures are similar or different?" Responses range from "very similar" to "very different" and indicate the extent to which individuals perceive China as culturally closer to Japan. It is reversely coded so higher value means perceived similarity, which is expected to increase openness to engagement with China.

Party identification is included to account for ideological and partisan cues that may influence foreign policy attitudes. Respondents are asked: “Which political party do you identify with?” and categorized as LDP, opposition, or Independents. We create two dummy variables, using LDP as the reference group. Given the LDP’s long-standing commitment to strengthening the US–Japan alliance, individuals outside the LDP coalition—opposition identifiers and independents—may exhibit weaker attachment to the US security partnership and thus potentially greater openness to accommodating China.

Finally, all models include standard demographic controls: gender, age (in five 10-year brackets), and education (middle school, high school, professional school, and university). These controls help account for individual-level variation that may confound the effects of our key predictors. [Supplementary Appendix Table A1](#) has all of the wording of important variables.

5.3 Models

Given that the two dependent variables are ordinal outcomes with five categories, we estimate ordinary logit models to test our hypotheses. Assume that Y^* is a latent continuous variable to predict an ordinal outcome out of five categories, it can be modeled as $\beta_0 + \beta_1 sdo + \beta_2 influence + \beta_3 CulturalSimilar + \beta_4 partisan + \beta_5 gender + \beta_6 age + \beta_7 edu$.

H3 expects that the effect of perceived Chinese influence on alignment preference is conditioned by hierarchy-orientation, SDO. The interaction between SDO and perception of China’s dominance is added to the equation.

$$\begin{aligned} \text{logit}(P(Y \leq j)) = & \alpha_j - \beta_0 + \beta_1 sdo + \beta_2 influence \\ & + \beta_3 CulturalSimilar + \beta_4 partisan + \beta_5 gender + \beta_6 age \\ & - \beta_7 edu + \beta_8 influence * sdo \text{ for } j = 1, \dots, 4 \end{aligned}$$

6. Results

We evaluate our hypotheses using the results presented in [Table 2](#) (national security models) and [Table 3](#) (economic development models), with a summary provided in [Table 1](#). [Table 1](#) summarizes our findings,

Table 1 The results of hypothesis testing

	National Security		Economic Development	
	Model 1	Model 2	Model 1	Model 2
H1 (SDO)	V	V	X	V
H2 (Power)	X	V	V	V
H3 (SDO ×Power)	—	V	—	V
H4 (Cultural Similarity)	X	—	V	—
H5 (Party ID)	V	V	X	X

Note: X means a hypothesis is not supported by our evidence; V means a hypothesis is supported by our evidence; — means that there is no hypothesis testing in that category.

which evaluate specific hypotheses using national security models (Table 2) and economic development models (Table 3).

Table 2 presents ordered logit estimates of alignment orientation in the security domain. Consistent with H1, SDO is positively associated with support for closer security alignment with China. This effect is statistically significant in both the baseline and interaction models, indicating that hierarchy-oriented individuals are more receptive to accommodating China’s rise in the security realm.

Contrary to H2, perceptions of China’s regional influence do not exert a direct effect on security alignment in the baseline specification. However, once interacted with SDO, perceived influence becomes conditionally relevant. As shown by the negative and significant interaction term, the pro-China effect of SDO weakens as China is increasingly perceived as the dominant regional power. This pattern supports H3 and suggests that hierarchy-oriented individuals are most responsive to power shifts when regional dominance is contested rather than settled.

Cultural similarity with China does not significantly predict security alignment, offering no support for H4 in the security domain. Party identification, however, remains consequential: opposition party identifiers and independents are more likely than LDP supporters to favor closer security relations with China, consistent with the LDP’s long-standing emphasis on the US–Japan alliance.

Table 3 reports results for economic alignment orientation. In contrast to the security domain, SDO does not exert a consistent independent effect. While SDO becomes weakly significant in the interaction

Table 2 Ordered Logit Estimation Of National Security Alignment Models

	Baseline Coefficient	Model Standard Error	With Coefficient	Interaction Standard Error
SDO	0.723*	(0.394)	2.419***	(0.935)
China's Influence	0.085	(0.077)	0.332**	(0.145)
China's Influence × SDO			-0.617**	(0.308)
Cultural Similarity	0.083	(0.118)	0.106	(0.119)
Partisanship (Base:LDP)				
Opposition Party	0.745***	(0.271)	0.731***	(0.270)
Independents	0.462**	(0.192)	0.429**	(0.193)
Gender (Female)	0.421**	(0.180)	0.445**	(0.181)
Age (Base: 18–29 years old)				
30–39 years old	-0.410	(0.314)	-0.419	(0.313)
40–49 years old	-0.278	(0.295)	-0.319	(0.296)
50–59 years old	-0.349	(0.304)	-0.387	(0.305)
60–69 years old	-0.048	(0.308)	-0.053	(0.308)
70–75 years old	0.005	(0.331)	-0.012	(0.331)
Education (Base: Middle School)				
High School	0.062	(0.522)	-0.008	(0.523)
Some College	0.330	(0.530)	0.239	(0.532)
University	0.264	(0.505)	0.168	(0.508)
Cutpoint 1 2	0.226	(0.700)	0.721	(0.743)
Cutpoint 2 3	2.116***	(0.707)	2.623***	(0.753)
Cutpoint 3 4	2.951***	(0.714)	3.464***	(0.760)
Cutpoint 4 5	4.352***	(0.747)	4.868***	(0.792)
<i>N</i>	489		489	
McFadden R^2	0.499		0.500	
Nagelkerke R^2	0.924		0.925	

Note:

* $P < 0.1$.

** $P < 0.05$.

*** $P < 0.01$.

Source: Authors.

model, its influence remains conditional and substantially smaller than in the security domain.

Perceived Chinese influence, by contrast, is a robust predictor of economic alignment. Across model specifications, respondents who

Table 3 Ordered Logit Estimation of Economic Development Alignment Models.

	Baseline Coefficient	Model Standard Error	With Coefficient	Interaction Standard Error
SDO	0.037	(0.385)	1.619*	(0.916)
China's Influence	0.238***	(0.076)	0.467***	(0.143)
China's Influence × SDO			−0.574*	(0.301)
Cultural Similarity	0.240**	(0.116)	0.261**	(0.117)
Partisanship (Base:LDP)				
Opposition Party	0.449*	(0.267)	0.439*	(0.266)
Independents	0.505***	(0.189)	0.479**	(0.190)
Gender (Female)	−0.027	(0.179)	−0.008	(0.179)
Age (Base: 18–29 years old)				
30–39 years old	−0.534*	(0.308)	−0.535*	(0.307)
40–49 years old	−0.250	(0.293)	−0.280	(0.293)
50–59 years old	−0.309	(0.299)	−0.331	(0.300)
60–69 years old	0.186	(0.304)	0.188	(0.304)
70–75 years old	−0.038	(0.329)	−0.039	(0.328)
Education (Base: Middle school)				
High School	−0.198	(0.510)	−0.270	(0.513)
Some College	−0.061	(0.522)	−0.144	(0.526)
University	−0.109	(0.495)	−0.189	(0.498)
Cutpoint 1 2	−1.047	(0.681)	−0.574	(0.726)
Cutpoint 2 3	0.588	(0.680)	1.072	(0.728)
Cutpoint 3 4	1.564**	(0.684)	2.054***	(0.734)
Cutpoint 4 5	3.098***	(0.708)	3.589***	(0.756)
N	475		475	
McFadden R ²	0.482		0.484	
Nagelkerke R ²	0.931		0.932	

Note:
**P* < 0.1,
***P* < 0.05,
****P* < 0.01.
Source: Authors.

view China as more influential in Asia are significantly more likely to support closer economic engagement, providing strong support for H2. The interaction between SDO and perceived influence is negative,

indicating that the effect of perceived Chinese influence on alignment orientation weakens as SDO increases, consistent with the idea that hierarchy-oriented individuals are most responsive under conditions of uncertainty and contestation rather than settled dominance.

Cultural similarity with China plays a central role in economic alignment. Respondents who perceive greater cultural affinity with China are significantly more supportive of economic engagement, confirming H4 and highlighting the domain-specific importance of identity-based considerations. Party identification also matters in this domain, with opposition party identifiers and independents exhibiting greater openness to economic alignment with China than LDP supporters.

Figures 2 and 3 highlight the conditional nature of SDO's influence across domains and are consistent with H1–H3, offering directional support for the theorized relationships. In the security domain, higher SDO is associated with greater support for closer relations with China when China's influence is perceived as weaker than the USA, but this relationship weakens and becomes statistically indistinguishable from zero as China is viewed as clearly dominant. This pattern suggests that hierarchy-oriented individuals are especially responsive during periods of contested hierarchy rather than settled dominance.

In the economic domain, although the interaction term reaches marginal significance, conditional marginal effects are weak. This indicates that dispositional preferences toward hierarchy play a more limited role in shaping economic alignment, where material interests and cultural similarity are more salient.

To summarize, these results highlight how both structural cues and psychological predispositions—individually and in interaction—shape Japanese people's attitude toward alignment in the shadow of US–China competition.

7. Robustness checks

To assess the stability of these findings, we estimate several alternative specifications. Because listwise deletion reduces the analytic sample by about 20%, we estimate multiple imputation models using predictive mean matching ($m=20$). In sum, all results are robust to alternative specifications, including conservatism controls, multinomial logit,

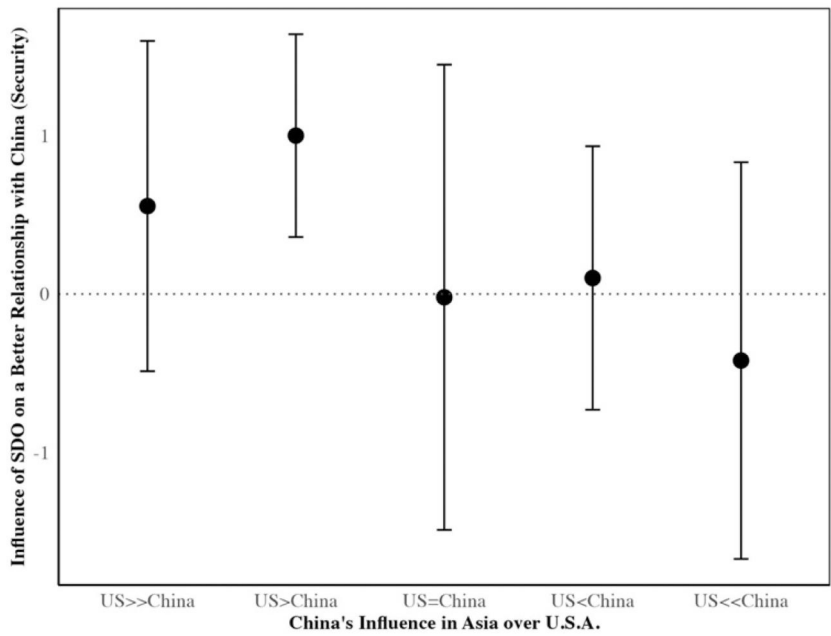


Figure 2 Marginal effect of SDO on national security across levels of China's influence.

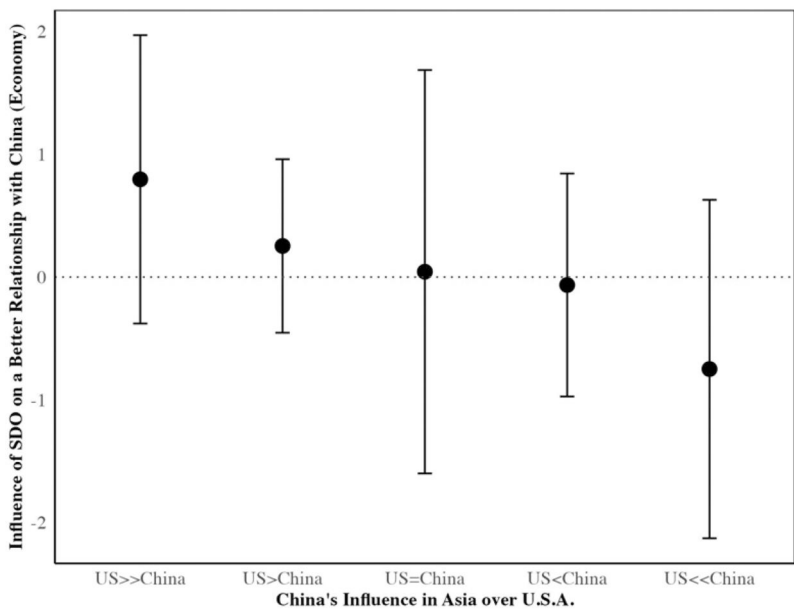


Figure 3 Marginal effect of SDO on economic development across levels of China's influence.

ordinary least squares, multiple imputation, and outcome recoding. These consistent results also address the concern of endogeneity. Full results appear in [Supplementary Appendix B](#).²

8. Conclusion and implications

This study demonstrates that mass public alignment posture is shaped by SDO, perceptions of regional power, and partisanship in the security domain, whereas cultural similarity plays a central role in structuring alignment orientation in the economic arena. We further find that SDO and perceptions of regional power operate as complementary mechanisms: power perceptions directly shift support for closer relations with China, while SDO conditions who is most responsive to these shifting hierarchical signals under conditions of contested dominance.

The core contribution of this analysis lies in integrating SDO and contested dominance into models of foreign policy evaluation. We show that citizens perceive states as status-bearing groups, enabling SDO to function as a hierarchy-oriented disposition that provides a psychological lens through which individuals evaluate rising powers, alliance commitments, and foreign policy choices. In this sense, alignment orientation are not merely reactions to material power shifts but are filtered through deeper motivational orientations toward hierarchy in international politics.

The innovation of this study is that alignment orientation is partially structured not only by perceived material threats or economic dependence, but also by underlying psychological orientations. Individuals exposed to the same structural pressures—China’s accelerating military and economic influence—arrive at markedly different alignment choices depending on their baseline levels of SDO and

2 Regarding the relationship between SDO and conservatism, we thank the referee for directing us to [Mifune and Yokota \(2018\)](#) and [Takahashi, Imada, and Mifune \(2025\)](#). [Mifune and Yokota \(2018\)](#) show that SDO is positively correlated with political conservatism, particularly on territorial issues such as the Takeshima and Senkaku Islands disputes. Using Bayesian methods, [Takahashi, Imada, and Mifune \(2025\)](#) replicate these findings and demonstrate that the association between SDO and issue positions remains largely unchanged even after controlling for conservatism. Together, these studies suggest that SDO and conservatism overlap empirically but are not reducible to one another. Accordingly, it is necessary to control for conservatism when using SDO to predict responses to China’s coercive behavior.

cultural ties. The heterogeneity of responses to power transition may make strategic communication—how governments describe power transitions—critical to formation of alignment orientation. Public alignment predisposition becomes fragmented along psychological lines, requiring more deliberate political signaling and alliance management from national leaders.

This study also advances research on foreign-policy making in middle-power states in Asia, such as South Korea, Australia, and Canada (Choi 2009). For example, South Korea's shift from "light hedging" under the Moon administration to "hard hedging" adopted by the Yoon administration amid heightened tensions between China and USA (Jin and Kim 2026). Although driven by multiple factors, this shift is consistent with the idea that hierarchy-oriented publics reassess alignment choices during contested hegemony. This framework also helps contextualize Japan's consistently strong public support for the US alliance since the Abe administration: because most Japanese citizens continue to perceive the USA as the dominant regional power, the conditions for SDO-driven openness to an alternative Chinese-led hierarchy have not been met.³ In the absence of hierarchical ambiguity, foreign policies remain anchored in the incumbent US-led regional structure.

In conclusion, this study sheds light on the formation of alignment orientation by identifying the hierarchy-based mechanism that interacts with the perception of contested power. SDO provides a distinct contribution to existing alignment theories by supplying the microfoundations they typically leave unspecified. Classic approaches to alignment—balancing, bandwagoning, hedging—assume that individuals interpret structural shifts in similar ways, responding uniformly to changes in relative power. Yet persistent heterogeneity in alignment

3 A range of public opinion polls indicates that Japanese citizens consistently perceive the USA as the dominant power. A Pew Research Center survey conducted in June 2021 found that 81% of Japanese respondents believed it was more important for Japan to maintain strong economic ties with the USA, compared to only 15% who prioritized ties with China (Silver 2021). A July 2025 poll similarly reported that 68% of Japanese viewed the USA as the world's leading economy, while only 11% identified China as the economic leader (Silver et al. 2025). Confidence in US primacy extends beyond economics: a March 2022 survey found that 54% of Japanese respondents were confident in US economic superiority over China, and 64% expressed confidence in US military superiority (Kafura et al. 2022).

orientation suggests that citizens process power transitions differently, even when exposed to identical geopolitical conditions. SDO fills this conceptual gap by specifying the psychological mechanism through which structural ambiguity produces divergent alignment orientation.

Our research implies that public opinion is not a passive reflection of geopolitical conditions but is shaped by an active, patterned, and psychologically grounded force. As Japan continues to navigate the strategic challenges posed by China, understanding these underlying predispositions will remain essential for anticipating how the public interprets risk, evaluates alliances, and envisions Japan's place in a transforming regional order.

Supplementary data

Supplementary data is available at *International Relations of the Asia-Pacific Journal* online.

Conflict of interest statement. None declared.

Data availability statement

The data that support the findings of this study are openly available in the Open Science Framework (OSF) at <https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/SGE7U>, under the project title "Japan Foreign Policy Opinion, 2024"

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